

In Ethereum's white paper that initially described its inner workings, Buterin's team made no qualms about their aspirations:

What is more interesting about Ethereum, however, is that the Ethereum protocol moves far beyond just currency. Protocols around decentralized file storage, decentralized computation and decentralized prediction markets, among dozens of other such concepts, have the potential to substantially increase the efficiency of the computational industry, and provide a massive boost to other peer-to-peer protocols by adding for the first time an economic layer.¹⁰

Importantly, Buterin did not intend for Ethereum and its native asset, ether, to be a minor variation on Bitcoin's codebase. This distinguished Ethereum from many of the altcoins that came before it.

By having no affiliation with "coin" in its name, Ethereum was moving beyond the idea of currency into the realm of *cryptocommodities*. While Bitcoin is mostly used to send monetary value between people, Ethereum could be used to send information between programs. It would do so by building a decentralized world computer with a *Turing complete programming language*.¹¹ Developers could write programs, or applications, that would run on top of this decentralized world computer. Just as Apple builds the hardware and operating system that allows developers to build applications on top, Ethereum was promising to do the same in a distributed and global system. Ether, the native unit, would come into play as follows:

Ether is a necessary element—a fuel—for operating the distributed application platform Ethereum. It is a form of payment made by the clients